GITHUB COPILOT DEV DAYS 2026 · COLOMBO

> copilot --agent team-aware

From Generic to Team-Aware

Teaching GitHub Copilot how your team works

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QUICK POLL

Which convention does AI break most often in your team?

A

Naming and folder structure

B

Error handling

C

Writing tests

D

Security and secrets

E

Logging personal data

Raise your hand for your top pick.

THE PROBLEM

Copilot knows code. It doesn’t know your team.

What it already knows

- Languages and frameworks
- Common patterns and idioms
- Public best practices

What it can’t guess

- Your folder structure and naming
- Your error format
- Your review rules
- What must never be logged

THE BIG IDEA

Better context, better code.

Every team can use the same models. Your context is what makes Copilot yours.

THE PLAN FOR TODAY

Three layers, one repo

1	**Instructions**	Always-on team rules	`.github/copilot-instructions.md`
2	**Skills**	Know-how loaded when relevant	`.github/skills/<name>/SKILL.md`
3	**Custom agents**	Specialists with limited tools	`.github/agents/<name>.agent.md`

THE DEMO

Meet the demo repo

`github-dev-days-2026`

A small Node.js + TypeScript API for bus seat booking, with a test suite.

One branch per layer, so we can jump ahead if a live step misbehaves.

Branch	What it adds
01-vanilla	Nothing yet
02-instructions	Team rules
03-skill	NIC validation skill
04-agent	Security reviewer

LAYER 1 · INSTRUCTIONS

Write the team rules down once

Lives in the repo

Everyone who clones it gets the same rules.

Applies to every request

So keep it short: rules, not essays.

AGENTS.md works too

Use it if your team already has one.

.github/copilot-instructions.md

```
# Team conventions
- TypeScript strict mode, no any
- Errors return { code, message }
- Every endpoint ships with a test
- Never log NIC or phone numbers
```

LIVE DEMO · LAYER 1

Same prompt, new rules

01

```
> Add an endpoint to cancel a booking
```

WATCH FOR

- The error format matches our rule
- A test file appears without being asked
- No phone numbers in the logs

LAYER 2 · AGENT SKILLS

Package know-how as a skill

.github/skills/nic-validation/SKILL.md

```
---
name: nic-validation
description: Validate Sri Lankan NIC
numbers, old and new formats
---
Use scripts/validate-nic.ts.
Never write a raw NIC to logs.
```

Loads on demand

Only when the task needs it.

Brings its own tools

Scripts and examples, not only text.

Works everywhere

Same skill in the terminal and the editor.

LIVE DEMO · LAYER 2

Teach it something only we know

02

```
> Validate the NIC field on the passenger form
```

WATCH FOR

- Copilot picks up the skill without being told
- It reuses our script instead of inventing a regex
- Both NIC formats are handled

LAYER 3 · CUSTOM AGENTS AND PLAN MODE

Give specialists a narrow job

.github/agents/security-reviewer.agent.md

```
---
name: security-reviewer
description: Review changes for
secrets and personal data
tools: ['read', 'search']
---
You review. You never edit files.
```

Fewer tools, less risk

A reviewer that can read but not write.

Plan before code

Approve the plan first. Shift+Tab in the CLI.

Call it by name

/agent in the CLI, or the agent picker in VS Code.

LIVE DEMO · LAYER 3

Plan first, then let the specialist review

03

```
> /agent security-reviewer
```

WATCH FOR

- The plan appears before any file changes
- The reviewer reads but cannot edit
- Findings point to exact files and lines

SCALING IT

Commit it once, the whole team gets it

```
your-repo/
.github/
copilot-instructions.md
skills/
agents/
```



- **Terminal** · Copilot CLI
- **Editor** · VS Code
- **New joiners** · on day one

Review these files in pull requests, like any other code.

KEEPING COSTS PREDICTABLE

Spend context where it counts

Keep instructions short

Always-on rules travel with every request.

Move detail into skills

They load only when the task needs them.

Plan before you build

An approved plan means fewer wasted retries.

Watch your usage

Check the billing page while you tune your setup.

RECAP

Generic versus team-aware

Moment	Generic Copilot	Team-aware Copilot
New endpoint	Its own error shape	Our { code, message } format
NIC field	An invented regex	Our tested validator
Security	Hope a reviewer notices	A reviewer agent checks it

TRY IT ON MONDAY

Three steps for your team

1

Write five team rules into your instructions file

2

Turn one task you repeat often into a skill

3

Create one read-only reviewer agent

THANK YOU

Questions?

STARTER SETUP

`github.com/nisalrenuja/github-dev-days-2026`

FIND ME

LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/nisalrenuja